

Playing It Safe:

Managerial Speech Uncertainty and Corporate Financial Conservatism

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Abstract

[PLACEHOLDER]

*ABSTRACT (target 150–200 words). Must cover: (i) Measurement of managerial speech uncertainty from earnings conference calls using the DWZ (2021) persistent-style framework, decomposed into answer-side (Q&A, *UncAnsMgr*) and presentation-side (scripted, *UncPreMgr*) components, and extended beyond the CEO to the full management team. (ii) Main finding: speech uncertainty predicts corporate financial conservatism across cash holdings, leverage, dividends, and buybacks. (iii) Defensive-investment result: capex rises under manager uncertainty and is amplified by product-market competition — a competitive real-options story rather than classical wait-and-see delay. (iv) Sample: 112,968 earnings calls, 2,429 firms, 2002–2018 (Compustat, CapIQ, Execucomp, CRSP). (v) External validation: the measure responds to macro economic policy uncertainty, political risk, and product-market competition — it is not noise.*

Keywords:

[PLACEHOLDER]

Keywords — managerial speech uncertainty; earnings conference calls; precautionary cash holdings; financial conservatism; competitive real options; DWZ 2021.

JEL Classification:

[PLACEHOLDER]

JEL codes — G30 (General Corporate Finance); G32 (Financing Policy; Capital Structure); G35 (Payout Policy); D81 (Criteria for Decision-Making under Risk and Uncertainty); M41 (Accounting).

1 Introduction

[PLACEHOLDER]

INTRODUCTION must cover, in order:

1. **Hook.** *Why managerial communication on earnings calls matters for corporate policy: investors, analysts, and the disclosure literature all treat the call as a signal, but the specific content of uncertainty in managerial language has been measured almost exclusively for the CEO.*
2. **Gap.** *Prior work (DWZ 2021 and followers) focuses on CEO and CFO language separately and on the full call; we extend the measurement to the broader management team (CFO + non-CEO speakers in the Q&A) and decompose the measure into answer-side (Q&A, spontaneous) and presentation-side (scripted) components.*
3. **Central claim.** *Managerial speech uncertainty predicts corporate financial conservatism: cash holdings rise, leverage drifts down at the one-quarter lead, dividends fall, share repurchases fall.*
4. **Narrative tension / secondary claim.** *Capital expenditure rises with manager uncertainty and the effect is amplified by product-market competition. We frame this as a competitive real-options result in the spirit of Grenadier (2002) and Aguerrevere (2009): when waiting risks preemption, uncertain managers invest defensively to preserve market position.*
5. **Data footprint.** *112,968 earnings conference calls, 2,429 unique firms, 2002 Q1–2018 Q4. Sources: CapIQ call transcripts and speaker metadata, Compustat quarterly fundamentals, CRSP daily prices, Execucomp CEO/CFO flags.*
6. **External validation.** *The measure is not noise: it responds to macro economic policy uncertainty (Baker-Bloom-Davis), political risk (Hassan et al.), and product-market competition (Hoberg-Phillips TSIMM).*
7. **Contribution.** *(a) Decomposition of managerial speech uncertainty into answer vs. presentation channels; (b) extension beyond CEO to full management; (c) identification of multiple conservatism channels inside a single firm-quarter panel; (d) the defensive-investment*

result as a contribution to the uncertainty–investment literature.

8. **Roadmap.** *Section II lays out the framework, measurement, and estimation. Section III presents the main results. Section IV collects additional analyses, validity tests, and null boundary results. Section V concludes.*
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2 Conceptual Framework and Empirical Strategy

2.1 Conceptual Framework

[PLACEHOLDER]

Frame financial conservatism as the core dependent construct. Draw on four literatures: (i) precautionary cash holdings (Bates, Kahle, & Stulz 2009; Opler, Pinkowitz, Stulz, & Williamson 1999); (ii) capital structure and leverage adjustment (Myers 1984 pecking order; Frank & Goyal 2003); (iii) payout smoothing and dividend commitment (Lintner 1956; Brav, Graham, Harvey, & Michaely 2005); (iv) real options and uncertainty-investment (Dixit & Pindyck 1994; Bloom 2014 — note: asymmetric payoffs, not “explore/resolve uncertainty” per memory correction). The novelty is the IV, not the DVs: we use a new measure of manager speech uncertainty to identify the conservatism response in a single firm-quarter panel.

2.2 Theory: Managerial Speech Uncertainty as a Persistent Style

[PLACEHOLDER]

Build on ? persistent managerial style. Key points:

- Managers exhibit persistent linguistic styles across calls.
- We decompose uncertainty into answer-side (*UncAns*) and presentation-side (*UncPre*) components, mirroring the scripted/unscripted distinction in the calls.
- We extend from CEO-only to a full management grouping (*UncAnsMgr*, *UncPreMgr*) that pools the CFO and other non-CEO executives speaking on the call.
- Procedural precedent for management-level measurement: Bushee, Gow, & Taylor (2018) — via Ian Gow’s *iangow/bgt* replication code.

- Procedural precedent for CFO measurement: Larcker & Zakolyukina (2012), using the *FactSet XML* title field.

2.3 Estimation of Main Variables

[PLACEHOLDER]

Describe the linguistic uncertainty dictionary, normalization, and the manager-vs-CEO speaker classification pipeline:

- Loughran–McDonald uncertainty word list, call-share normalization, DWZ 2021 style-residual persistence component.
- Speaker classification: *Execucomp ceoann/cfoann* annual flags merged on *gvkey-year*; manager classifier picks up remaining executives from transcript metadata.
- **Known blocker:** current *UncAnsMgr* construction is broken in the pipeline (memory *project_step22_schema_bug*); CFO / *ManagerV2* rebuild plan is finalized (memory *project_cfo_mgrv2_plan_v2*) and ready to execute. Results in the tables reflect the current working build; we will rerun after the rebuild.

2.4 Methodology and Empirical Design

[PLACEHOLDER]

- **Panel.** Firm-quarter, 2002 Q1–2018 Q4. Main sample excludes financial firms (SIC 6000–6999) and utilities (SIC 4900–4999).
- **Estimator.** PanelOLS via Python *linearmodels*. Two-way clustering at the firm and calendar-year-quarter level. Calendar year-quarter fixed effects (not fiscal) per memory *feedback_calendar_yr_qtr_fe*.

- **12-column specification ladder.** *Three specifications (Industry+Year, Industry+Year+Extended Controls, Firm+Year, Firm+Year+Extended Controls, Year-Quarter FE variants) applied contemporaneously and at the one-quarter lead, giving 12 columns per main-table DV.*
 - **Lagged DV as base control** in every column (*memory feedback_lagged_dv*).
 - **Inference.** *IVs tested one-tailed when direction is predicted (financial-conservatism hypotheses); controls two-tailed.*
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2.5 Specification and Measurement of Key Constructs

[PLACEHOLDER]

Base controls: *lnAssets, TobinsQ, ROA, Leverage, Capex, CashRatio, DivDummy, sCFD, Lagged_DV.*

Extended controls: *SalesGrowth, RDSales, CashFlowAt, DailyVola.*

Bad-control exclusions: *per DV, we drop controls that share the dependent variable's numerator concept (memory feedback_bad_control_exclusion). For example, when CashRatio is the DV we do not use CashFlowAt and CashRatio itself as right-hand-side controls; the full map is enforced by the shared runner configuration.*

3 Main Empirical Analyses

3.1 Data, Sample, and Variable Construction

[PLACEHOLDER]

Sample. 112,968 earnings conference calls, 2,429 unique firms, 2002 Q1–2018 Q4. Build pipeline:

- CapIQ call transcripts and structured speaker metadata; CFO/non-CEO manager flags via Execucomp ceoann/ cfoann annual fields merged on gvkey–year.
- Compustat quarterly fundamentals for financial-statement items.
- CRSP daily prices and volume for microstructure tests in Appendix II.
- Main sample excludes financial (SIC 6000–6999) and utility (SIC 4900–4999) firms.

Table 1 Summary Statistics placeholder — generate from findings.txt or a dedicated summary script.

3.2 Precautionary Liquidity: Cash Holdings and the Rating Channel

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. Uncertain managers hoard cash; financial constraint — proxied by being unrated — amplifies the effect.

- **H1 (Table ??).** *UncAnsMgr* +0.0034** to +0.0072*** across the six contemporaneous specifications of *CashRatio*; lead horizon weaker.
- **H1.2 (Table ??).** Three-category rating moderation: main effect *Manager_QA_Unc_c* +0.0055*** to +0.0057***; unrated interaction *MgrQAUnc_x_Unrated* +0.0068*** to +0.0073***. Below-investment-grade interaction null.

- **Interpretation.** Classical precautionary savings motive [?] amplified when external liquidity access is absent. The unrated firm is the marginal cash hoarder.

References: Tables ??, ??.

3.3 Capital-Structure Discipline: Book Leverage and Debt-to-Capital

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. Deleveraging is sluggish. Nothing appears contemporaneously, but a modest negative pull shows up at the one-quarter lead.

- **H4a (Table ??).** *UncAnsMgr* null contemporaneously; –0.0050* to –0.0090** at the lead, surviving firm and year-quarter fixed effects.
- **H4b (Table ??).** Mostly null; a single –0.0154*** at lead in one specification. Weakest of the two.
- **Honest caveat.** This is the weakest section of the main body. Frame as suggestive deleveraging, not a headline. Discuss the pecking-order implication and flag that formal financing-choice margins (H19b, H20b in Appendix I) are similarly fragile.

References: Tables ??, ??.

3.4 Distribution Restraint: Dividends, Payer Status, and Repurchases

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. When managers sound uncertain, cash stays in the firm. Dividends fall, the probability of being a dividend payer falls, and share repurchases fall. Combined, these three channels show that total distributions to shareholders contract.

- **H12 (Table ??).** Quarterly Payout Ratio. *UncPreMgr* –0.0299** to –0.0529*** — presentation-side channel.

- **H12b (Table ??).** Dividend Payer Indicator (Hoberg-Prabhala 2009 analog, linear probability + firm FE). $UncPreMgr -0.0055^{**}$ to -0.0113^{***} .
- **H17 (Table ??).** Repurchase Intensity (decumulated $prstkcy$). $UncAnsMgr -0.0005^{*}$ to -0.0008^{***} contemporaneously, with $UncPreMgr$ showing a small positive partial correlation ($+0.0005^{*}$ to $+0.0007^{**}$) — a partial cross-channel tension flagged below.
- **Channel note.** Payouts run through presentation-side uncertainty ($UncPreMgr$); repurchases run through answer-side uncertainty ($UncAnsMgr$). Whether to feature this as a two-channel contribution or smooth it over is an open decision (see DECISIONS.md §3.3).

References: Tables ??, ??, ??.

Open: H17 placement pending user confirmation — current proposal groups it here with payouts under total distribution.

3.5 Defensive Investment: Capital Expenditure and the Competition Channel

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. Capex rises under manager uncertainty, and the effect is amplified by product-market competition. This is **the central narrative tension** with the “playing it safe” title: on the surface, more investment looks like more risk-taking. We reconcile it as a competitive real-options result: when waiting risks preemption, the option value of delay collapses, and the uncertain manager invests defensively to preserve competitive position.

- **H13 (Table ??).** $UncAnsMgr +0.0020^{***}$ to $+0.0049^{***}$ in the extended-control specifications.
- **H13.1 (Table ??).** Product-similarity moderation: main effect $+0.0010^{**}$ to $+0.0017^{**}$, interaction $MgrQAUnc_x_zlogTSIMM +0.0011^{*}$ to $+0.0024^{**}$ (positive — competition amplifies the effect).

- **Theoretical framing.** Classical real options [?] predicts less investment under uncertainty. We instead see more. The competitive real-options literature [??] rationalizes this: in a setting where rivals may preempt, waiting has negative strategic value, and the optimal response to higher uncertainty can be earlier exercise. Our H13.1 interaction sign is the empirical signature of this mechanism.
- **Persistence.** The effect is not a one-quarter blip. See Appendix 4.1 (H13.2) for lead horizons $t + 1$ through $t + 4$.

References: Tables ??, ??.

Open: H13 framing is the central open decision (DECISIONS.md §3.1). Options: (a) defensive-hedge framing (current proposal); (b) split thesis, two independent stories; (c) demote H13 out of main.

3.6 Non-Distinguishing Investment: Research and Development

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. R&D does not respond to managerial speech uncertainty in either direction.

- **H16 (Table ??).** $RDSales$ (Jiang 2021 construction, $xrdy/saley$). All four IVs are statistically null across all 12 specifications.
- **Interpretation.** R&D is a long-horizon, partly sticky commitment: prior-period research projects, accounting treatment under ASC 730, and staffing contracts all buffer R&D from short-run communication signals. Absence of response is itself informative — it distinguishes R&D from capex (H13) and suggests the defensive-investment mechanism is tangible-capacity specific.

Reference: Table ??.

Open: H16 placement pending user decision (DECISIONS.md §3.2). Options: keep here as “no response” or relocate to Appendix I.

4 Additional Analyses

4.1 Robustness, Channels, and Horizons (Appendix I)

4.1.1 Product-Similarity Channel for Cash (Null)

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. Competition does not moderate the cash story — the channel that works for capex (H13.1) does not work for precautionary liquidity.

- **H1.1 (Table ??).** Main Manager_QA_Unc_c +0.0045***; z_log_TotalSimilarity +0.0057***; interaction MgrQAUnc_x_zlogTSIMM +0.0017 (null).
- **Binary variant H1.1b (Table ??).** MgrQAUnc_x_HighTSIMM +0.0010 (null).
- **Interpretation.** Precautionary cash hoarding is a general response to managerial uncertainty, not a competition-specific one. The investment decision is where competitive dynamics bite (H13.1).

References: Tables ??, ??.

4.1.2 Capex Persistence: Lead Horizons

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. The defensive-investment effect is not a one-quarter blip. Capex responds at $t + 1$ and the response grows through $t + 4$.

- **H13.2 (Table ??).** UncAnsMgr on Capex at:
 $t + 1$: +0.0049*** (Ind. FE spec), +0.0028*** (Firm FE spec).
 $t + 2$: +0.0036*** / +0.0035***.
 $t + 3$: +0.0070*** / +0.0049***.
 $t + 4$: +0.0071*** / +0.0048***.
- **Interpretation.** The competitive-preemption interpretation requires a sustained commitment to capacity, not a single project. The horizon results are consistent with that: uncertain managers commit to multi-quarter capex programs.

Reference: Table ??.

4.1.3 Financing-Mix Margins (Weak)

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. Direct financing-choice margins point in the conservative direction but are statistically fragile.

- **H19b (Table ??).** External vs. internal financing, Chang, Dasgupta, & Hilary (2006) cash-flow debt-classification. UncAnsMgr -0.0155^* to -0.0160^* at the lead — suggestive shift toward internal financing, consistent with the lagged deleveraging in H4a/b.
- **H20b (Table ??).** Debt vs. equity choice, same CDH (2006) framework. Mostly null; UncPreCEO -0.0269^* to -0.0320^{**} in two specifications.
- **Honest framing.** Directions are consistent with conservatism, but statistical strength is weak. These results reinforce rather than establish the capital-structure section in the main body.

References: Tables ??, ??.

4.2 Validity, Drivers, and Boundary Tests (Appendix II)

4.2.1 External Drivers of Managerial Speech Uncertainty

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. The measure is not noise. Managerial speech uncertainty responds to three independent external forcings — political risk, economic policy uncertainty, and product-market competition — all in the expected direction. This subsection validates the IV.

- **H11 (Table ??).** Contemporaneous Hassan et al. PRisk $\rightarrow$ uncertainty language: UncPreMgr coefficient +0.1174***; UncPreCEO coefficient +0.1078***.

- **H11-Lag (Table ??).** Lagged PRisk variant: +0.1219*** / +0.1122***, robust to both FE schemes.
- **H23 (Table ??).** Reverse-direction test of Hoberg-Phillips TSIMM $\rightarrow$ managerial uncertainty: $UncPreMgr$ +0.1943***; $UncPreCEO$ +0.2491***. Product-market competition increases hedged language.
- **H24 (Table ??).** $\log(US EPU)_t \rightarrow$ uncertainty: coefficient range +0.0117* to +0.0239*** across all eight specifications.
- **H24b (Table ??).** $\log(GEPU)_t \rightarrow$ uncertainty: +0.0124* to +0.0309*** across all eight specifications — same sign as US EPU. (Note: prior memory entry flagging a “wrong-sign” finding is stale; the rebuilt results align with US EPU in sign and magnitude. Memory to be updated.)
- **H25 (Table ??).** $\log(GPR)_t \rightarrow$ uncertainty: mostly null, with a single +0.0147* in the CEO presentation column. Geopolitical risk does not translate cleanly into firm-level managerial language in our sample period.

References: Tables ??, ??, ??, ??, ??, ??.

Open: DECISIONS.md §3.5 — whether to split this block into (a) macro/political (H11, H11-Lag, H24, H24b, H25) and (b) product-market (H23) as two separate sub-subsections.

4.2.2 Information-Environment Signals

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. Uncertain managerial speech correlates with higher analyst disagreement and higher SEC scrutiny. These are concurrent signals that the call transmits information to downstream market participants.

- **H5 (Table ??).** Wang (2020) analyst forecast dispersion $DISP$: $UncAnsMgr$ +0.0002*** — statistically robust but economically very small.
- **H18 (Table ??).** SEC comment letters (linear probability model): $UncPreMgr$ +0.0017* to +0.0020*.

- **H18b (Table ??).** SEC comment letters (logit robustness): $UncPreMgr$ +0.0012* to +0.0018**.

- **H21 (Table ??).** SEC comment letter count: $UncPreCEO$ +0.0134** to +0.0153**.

References: Tables ??, ??, ??, ??.

4.2.3 Market Microstructure (Null)

[PLACEHOLDER]

Subnarrative. Managerial speech uncertainty predicts corporate decisions but does not predict intraday microstructure. Ten tables of Amihud illiquidity and bid-ask spread tests over 3-day and 25-day post-call windows all return null. This is an informative boundary: the effects we document run through real corporate policy, not through trading-friction channels.

- **H7 family (Tables ??–??).** Amihud illiquidity: (a) 3-day change [+1, +3] – [−3, −1]; (b) 3-day level [+1, +3]; (c) BGT (2018) 25-day level [0, +25]; (d) BGT 25-day delta [+1, +25] – [−25, −1]; (e) BGT 51-day symmetric average [−25, +25]. All null on managerial IVs.
- **H14 family (Tables ??–??).** Lee (2016) bid-ask spread: same five window variants as H7. All null.

References: Tables ??–??, ??–??.

Open: DECISIONS.md §3.6 — whether to display all 10 tables separately, consolidate into one summary, or use two family-level summaries.

5 Conclusion

[PLACEHOLDER]

Recap.

1. **Contribution.** (a) Decomposition of managerial speech uncertainty into answer-side (*Q&A*, *UncAnsMgr*) and presentation-side (scripted, *UncPreMgr*) components; (b) extension from CEO-only to the full management team; (c) identification of multiple financial-conservatism channels in a single firm-quarter panel.
 2. **Main findings.** Precautionary cash rises; leverage drifts down at the one-quarter lead; dividends fall; repurchases fall; capex rises under competitive pressure as defensive pre-emption; R&D is unresponsive.
 3. **Validation.** The measure responds in expected directions to US EPU, Global EPU, political risk, and product-market competition.
 4. **Boundary.** No intraday liquidity response — the effect is corporate-policy, not microstructural.
 5. **Limitations.** Sample period 2002–2018 excludes the COVID shock and its aftermath. Current *UncAnsMgr* construction in the pipeline is broken pending the CFO / ManagerV2 rebuild (memory project_cfo_mgrv2_plan_v2); the present results should be replicated after that rebuild is executed.
 6. **Future work.** Channel moderation suites F2, F3, F5 not yet built; cross-country extensions; alternative definitions of the manager category; interaction with institutional ownership and analyst coverage.
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[PLACEHOLDER]

Populate references.bib. Minimum load-bearing set:

- *Speech / disclosure:* Davis, Ge, Matsumoto, & Zhang (2015); Loughran & McDonald (2011) *uncertainty dictionary*; Bushee, Gow, & Taylor (2018, JAR); Larcker & Zakolyukina (2012); ?.
- *Corporate conservatism:* Bates, Kahle, & Stulz (2009); Opler, Pinkowitz, Stulz, & Williamson (1999); Myers (1984); Frank & Goyal (2003); Lintner (1956); Brav, Graham, Harvey, & Michaely (2005); Hoberg & Prabhala (2009); Jiang (2021).
- *Real options and investment under uncertainty:* Dixit & Pindyck (1994); Bloom (2014); Grenadier (2002); Aguerrevere (2009).
- *Financing-choice margins:* Chang, Dasgupta, & Hilary (2006); Hoberg & Maksimovic.
- *Uncertainty IVs and validation:* Baker, Bloom, & Davis (EPU); Davis (GEPu); Caldara & Iacoviello (GPR); Hassan, Hollander, van Lent, & Tahoun (PRisk); Hoberg & Phillips (TSIMM).
- *Microstructure:* Amihud (2002); Lee (2016).
- *Dispersion / expectations:* Wang (2020).

A Variable Definition and Measurement

A.1 Dependent Variables

[PLACEHOLDER]

Populate verbatim from *findings.txt* DV formula block. Each entry must spell out every raw database item with its source (memory rule *feedback_dv_formula_documentation*). Required entries, in section order:

- *CashRatio* (H1) — Compustat *cheq/atq*.
 - *Leverage* (H4a) — $(dlcq + dlттq) / atq$.
 - *DebtToCapital* (H4b) — $(dlcq + dlттq) / (dlcq + dlттq + ceqq)$.
 - *PayoutRatio* (H12) — de-cumulated *dvy / ibq*.
 - *DivPayer* (H12b) — indicator of positive quarterly dividends (Hoberg-Prabhala 2009 analog).
 - *Capex* (H13, H13.1, H13.2) — de-cumulated *capxy / atq*.
 - *RDSales* (H16) — *xrdy / saley* (Jiang 2021).
 - *RepurchaseIntensity* (H17) — de-cumulated *prstkcy / atq*.
-

A.2 Independent Variables

[PLACEHOLDER]

- *UncAnsMgr* — manager answer-side (Q&A) uncertainty, DWZ (2021) persistent-style construction with Loughran-McDonald uncertainty word list. Built via *linguistic_engine* over the Q&A segment for non-CEO executives.
- *UncPreMgr* — manager presentation-side (scripted) uncertainty, same construction over the opening presentation segment.

- *UncAnsCEO*, *UncPreCEO* — CEO analogs, using Execucomp *ceoann* annual flag.
 - **Moderators:** *BelowIG*, *Unrated* (H1.2); *z_log_TotalSimilarity*, *HighTSIMM* (H1.1, H13.1).
-

A.3 Controls

[PLACEHOLDER]

Base: *lnAssets*, *TobinsQ*, *ROA*, *Leverage*, *CashRatio*, *Capex*, *DivDummy*, *sCFD*, *Lagged_DV*.

Extended: *SalesGrowth*, *RDSales*, *CashFlowAt*, *DailyVol*.

Bad-control exclusions. Per DV, controls that share the DV's numerator concept are dropped (e.g., *CashRatio* and *CashFlowAt* not used as controls when *CashRatio* is the DV). The full exclusion map is enforced by the shared runner configuration in *src/f1d/econometric/*.

B Tables

[PLACEHOLDER]

Table-fragment strategy. The authoritative `all_tables.tex` is a 2,350-line monolith generated by `generate_all_tables.py`. To use `\input{}` from this draft, we will need a future sub-task to split that monolith into per-suite fragments, e.g., `tables/tab_h1.tex`, `tables/tab_h1_2.tex`, Until that split is done, the `\input{}` hooks below are left commented out. Table-number references (`\ref{tab:h1}` etc.) will resolve once the fragments are imported.

Table 1. Summary Statistics

[PLACEHOLDER]

Generate from `findings.txt` or a dedicated summary script. Main sample: 112,968 calls, 2,429 firms, 2002 Q1–2018 Q4. Report mean / SD / N for all DVs, all four speech-uncertainty IVs, and the full control set. Break out by main sample (ex `fin&util`).

Table 2. H1 — Speech Uncertainty and Cash Holdings

[PLACEHOLDER]

H1 placeholder — `tables/tab_h1.tex`.

Table 3. H1.2 — Rating-Channel Moderation of Cash Holdings

[PLACEHOLDER]

H1.2 placeholder — three-category financial constraint.

Table 4. H4a — Book Leverage

[PLACEHOLDER]

H4a placeholder.

Table 5. H4b — Debt-to-Capital

[PLACEHOLDER]

H4b placeholder.

Table 6. H12 — Quarterly Payout Ratio

[PLACEHOLDER]

H12 placeholder.

Table 7. H12b — Dividend Payer Indicator

[PLACEHOLDER]

H12b placeholder — Hoberg-Prabhala 2009 analog.

Table 8. H13 — Capital Expenditure

[PLACEHOLDER]

H13 placeholder.

Table 9. H13.1 — Product-Similarity Moderation of Capex

[PLACEHOLDER]

H13.1 placeholder — TSIMM moderation interaction.

Table 10. H16 — R&D Investment Intensity

[PLACEHOLDER]

H16 placeholder — Jiang 2021 RDSales.

LPM), H18b (SEC comment letter logit), H21 (SEC comment letter count).

A.II.3 Market microstructure (null): *H7 family — 3-day Δ Amihud, 3-day Amihud level, BGT 25-day level, BGT 25-day Δ , BGT 51-day symmetric average. H14 family — 3-day Δ DSPREAD, 3-day DSPREAD level, BGT 25-day variants. Ten tables total; display strategy pending DECISIONS.md §3.6.*

Table 11. H17 — Repurchase Intensity

[PLACEHOLDER]

H17 placeholder.

Appendix I Tables (Main-Test Robustness)

[PLACEHOLDER]

A.I.1: H1.1 product-similarity moderation of cash (null interaction).

A.I.2: H1.1b binary TSIMM variant of H1.1 (null interaction).

A.I.3: H13.2 capex lead horizons $t+1$ through $t+4$.

A.I.4: H19b external vs. internal financing (CDH 2006).

A.I.5: H20b debt vs. equity choice (CDH 2006).

Appendix II Tables (Validity, Drivers, and Boundary Tests)

[PLACEHOLDER]

A.II.1 External drivers of managerial speech uncertainty: *H11 (PRisk contemporaneous), H11-Lag (lagged PRisk), H23 (TSIMM $\rightarrow$ uncertainty, reverse), H24 (US EPU), H24b (GEPU), H25 (GPR).*

A.II.2 Information environment signals: *H5 (Wang 2020 DISP), H18 (SEC comment letter*